The Cross

Mark 15 · Luke 23 · John 19 · Isaiah 53

The big idea: Jesus is the Lamb God provided. On the cross he bore God's wrath as our substitute, so that God is both just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus. A thief was saved with nothing to bring. "It is finished": nothing is left to pay.

Before you meet: Read

Luke 23:32–49 | Mark 15:33–39 | Isaiah 53:4–6

Open (5 minutes)

What do you think of when you see a cross?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Jesus, _____ me when you come into your kingdom." *(Luke 23:42)*

"My God, my God, why have you _____ me?" *(Mark 15:34)*

"But he was pierced for our _____; he was crushed for our iniquities." *(Isaiah 53:5)*

"For our sake he made him to be _____ who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." *(2 Corinthians 5:21)*

Discuss

1. Trace the lamb thread from Genesis 22 to the cross. Which link in that chain means the most to you now? *Genesis 22:8; Exodus 12:13; John 1:29*

2. The thief on the cross was saved with no time to do good works. What does that teach about how anyone is saved? *Luke 23:39–43*

3. Paul wrote that the Son of God loved me and gave himself for me. What would change if you really believed that? *Galatians 2:20; Romans 5:8*

Memory verse

> *"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."*
>
> **Isaiah 53:5**

Pray

Thank Jesus for drinking the cup of wrath, for taking the place of the guilty, and for crying, It is finished. Confess your sin and rest in his finished work. Like the thief, ask him to remember you, and thank him that there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 42

The Cross

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Luke 23:32–49 and Isaiah 53:4–6 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Mark 16:1–8, Luke 24, and John 20–21).

Main points to land

1. In Gethsemane and on the cross, Jesus drank the cup of God's wrath as our substitute, bearing the punishment our sins deserved (Mark 14:36; 15:34; 2 Corinthians 5:21).
2. The cross is propitiation: God is both just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus (Romans 3:26; 1 John 4:10).
3. It is finished. Nothing is left to pay, and there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (John 19:30; Hebrews 10:12–14; Romans 8:1).

Answer key (Observe)

1. remember
2. forsaken
3. transgressions
4. sin

Questions people will ask

Isn't it unjust for God to punish an innocent person for others?
It would be, if Jesus were an unwilling third party. But he is God the Son, who freely laid down his life (John 10:18), the Judge taking the penalty himself out of love (1 John 4:10). God does not ignore sin; he punishes it fully in his Son, so that he is both just and the justifier (Romans 3:26).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you are the Lamb God provided. You drank the cup we deserved, took the place of the guilty, and cried, It is finished. Thank you that you loved sinners and gave yourself for them. Help each of us to rest in your finished work, to turn from our sin, and to trust you alone. There is now no condemnation for those who are in you. Amen.